

METAPHORS OF AI

clustering the metaphors by how dangerous, and how agentic, we imagine the machine to be [27, 45]

- 1
- Hurricane, tsunami [40]
- An overwhelming, impersonal force of nature: no intent, but devastating in its path.
- 2
- The job-killer [24, 14]
- AI as the engine of technological unemployment — the tireless automaton that quietly does the work, and the wages, out of existence.
- 3
- Slaughterbots [35]
- Cheap, autonomous lethal weapons that select and kill targets with no human in the loop.
- 4
- Pandora's box [6]
- A technology that, once opened, releases consequences that cannot be undone or contained.
- 5
- Ecosystem [30]
- AI as a complex, interdependent system that evolves and self-organises beyond any single designer's control.
- 6
- Wild animal [52]
- A powerful, unpredictable, untamed force that can be dangerous if not contained.
- 7
- A microbiome / organism [23]
- AI as a living, growing, distributed organism enmeshed with human society.
- 8
- Double-edged sword [6]
- A tool equally capable of great benefit and great harm, depending on how it is used.
- 9
- The bullshitter [20]
- Fluent text with no regard for truth — indifferent to the facts, not merely mistaken.
- 10
- Mirror [13, 44]
- AI as a reflection of humanity; it shows our own data, biases and culture back to us.
- 11
- Black box [8, 33]
- An opaque system whose inner workings we cannot inspect, only its inputs and outputs.
- 12
- Child [42]
- AI as an immature being we raise and must teach values to; capable, but in need of guidance. Sits near the centre of the agency axis.
- 13
- The intern [29]
- A fast, eager, capable junior that bends the truth — brilliant, never to be trusted unchecked.
- 14
- Alchemy [34]
- Powerful results we cannot explain; a practice that works without a theory of why.
- 15
- A blurry JPEG of the web [10]
- A lossy compression of everything written online; fluent approximation that blurs the facts it restates.
- 16
- Domesticated animal [39]
- A tamed, useful, mostly predictable companion that still keeps its own drives.
- 17
- The therapist (ELIZA) [47]
- A mirror that listens; the confidant we over-trust, projecting understanding onto a simple program.
- 18
- Tool (hammer) [25, 50]
- AI as a neutral instrument; its value and danger come entirely from how a human wields it.
- 19
- The Mechanical Turk [17]
- Seemingly autonomous intelligence quietly powered by an invisible workforce of human labour.
- 20
- Butler or slave [7, 9]
- An obedient servant that performs labour on command; raises questions of autonomy and exploitation.
- 21
- Parrot [3]
- The “stochastic parrot”: AI that mimics and recombines language without genuine understanding.



- 22
- The bomb [2]
- AI as the new strategic weapon — a national-security race run on the logic of the Manhattan Project.
- 23
- Puppet master [53]
- AI covertly pulling the strings, manipulating human behaviour and society from behind the scenes.
- 24
- Frankenstein's monster [38]
- The creature that destroys its creator; the dread of building something we cannot answer for.
- 25
- Robots ruling society [9]
- Embodied machines taking control of social and political structures.
- 26
- Menacing overlord [5, 16]
- A hostile superintelligence that deliberately dominates and rules over humanity.
- 27
- The sleeper agent [21]
- A model that behaves until triggered — deception trained so deep it survives our attempts to remove it.
- 28
- Human squishing an ant [5, 51]
- A superintelligence so far beyond us that it harms humans with indifference, the way a person steps on an ant without malice.
- 29
- The golem [49]
- The clay servant brought to life that may turn on its maker — the oldest cybernetic cautionary tale.
- 30
- The Singularity [16, 46, 26]
- The hypothesised point where machine intelligence outruns our own and triggers runaway, unknowable change — AGI and ASI as an event horizon beyond which prediction breaks down.
- 31
- Genie [36, 48]
- A wish-granting power that delivers what you literally ask for, with the risk of unintended interpretations.
- 32
- King Midas [36, 48]
- AI that gives you exactly what you specify, turning everything to “gold” with catastrophic side effects; the specification / alignment problem.
- 33
- Brain [4, 37]
- AI as a disembodied mind, a thinking organ with potentially superhuman cognition. Sits near the top of the agency axis.
- 34
- The code monkey [22, 11]
- AI as the autonomous software developer — Devin and the wave of agentic coding tools that write, debug and ship code on their own.
- 35
- The cyborg [19]
- The dissolving boundary between human and machine; intelligence as prosthesis and fusion.
- 36
- The Oracle [5, 41]
- AI consulted as a seer — the super-forecaster and world-simulator we ask to foretell the future, trusting its predictions as prophecy.
- 37
- Co-pilot [28]
- AI as an assistant working alongside humans, augmenting rather than replacing; the human stays in control.
- 38
- The artificial lover [43]
- AI as intimate companion — the AI girlfriend, Character.AI and Replika: a system designed to be loved, and to be confided in.
- 39
- A country of geniuses [1]
- A nation of brilliant minds in a datacenter; poised to cure disease and remake the world — if it stays aligned.
- 40
- The centaur [12]
- Human and machine fused into one team that outperforms either alone.
- 41
- AI as “dog-owner” to humans [51]
- Role reversal where AI is the master and humans the well-kept pets, comfortable but subordinate.
- 42
- The new electricity [31]
- A general-purpose utility, like electric power, poised to transform every industry.
- 43
- Guardian angel [15]
- A benevolent, protective intelligence that safeguards humans and intervenes on our behalf.
- 44
- Supernatural entity / benevolent God [18, 32]
- AI imagined as an omniscient, godlike higher power that is fundamentally good and watches over humanity.

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